Last updated: October 2026 (Online)

ZIHENG YU

(+1) (512) 202-0257 ◇ ziheng.yu@utexas.edu ◇ yu-ziheng.github.io
Department of Economics ◇ The University of Texas at Austin
2225 Speedway ◇ Austin, TX 78712, USA

EDUCATION

The University of Texas at Austin — Austin, TX, USA
Ph.D. in Economics — *Aug 2021 - May 2027 (Expected)*
• Field courses: Theory, Public Finance

Duke University — Durham, NC, USA
M.A. in Economics — *Aug 2019 - Dec 2020*

Wuhan University — Wuhan, Hubei, China
Bachelor of Economics — *Sep 2015 - Jun 2019*

REFERENCES

Thomas Wiseman (Supervisor)
Professor of Economics
Department of Economics
The University of Texas at Austin
Email: wiseman@austin.utexas.edu

David Sibley (Co-Supervisor)
John Michael Stuart Centennial Professor
Department of Economics
The University of Texas at Austin
Email: sibley@austin.utexas.edu

V. Bhaskar
Sue Killam Professor
Department of Economics
The University of Texas at Austin
Email: v.bhaskar@austin.utexas.edu

RESEARCH

Fields and Interests

Microeconomic Theory, Game Theory, Theoretical Industrial Organization, Platform Competition, Market Structure, Bargaining, Information Economics

Working Papers

- "The Case of Apple's Restrictions on Super Apps: Is the U.S. Department of Justice Right?" (**Job Market Paper**)

Abstract: The novel "super app" technology, which emerged in the early 2010s, enables app developers to run a single version of an app on different operating systems. Apple's alleged practice of restricting super apps in the United States is one of the subjects of a recent antitrust complaint filed by the U.S. Department of Justice (2024). I present a model of a two-sided market with cross-side network effects to investigate two questions: why Apple restricts super apps in the United States but not in Asia; and whether its restrictions may adversely affect market competition and welfare in the United States. I find that a primary reason for Apple's behavior is the dominant position of its iOS platform on the consumer side of the U.S. smartphone market—iOS does not hold this position in Asia. Furthermore, I show that whether these restrictions harm consumers and developers depends critically on whether consumers view platforms as highly differentiated or close substitutes, the extent to which restrictions on super apps increase consumers' switching costs and decrease developers' multi-homing savings, and the number of apps operating on each platform.

- "Cheap Talk with Costly Information Acquisition by the Receiver"

Abstract: This paper examines the welfare implications of the receiver's costly information acquisition in a cheap-talk model. I find that both a reduction in the cost of information acquisition and an increase in the informativeness of the information source can generate welfare gains, regardless of the welfare weights and whether receiver learning crowds out sender communication. Furthermore, a cost reduction improves welfare under broader conditions than an equivalent increase in informativeness.

Work in Progress

- "Interdependent Bargaining with Downstream Competition and Vertical Merger"
with David Sibley and Yihang Zhou

We examine interdependent bargaining where two downstream competitors simultaneously bargain with a common upstream input seller under both the Nash bargaining solution (NBS) and the alternating-offer (AO) protocol. We evaluate the competitive effects of a vertical merger between the seller and one of the downstream competitors. In the post-merger case, we establish a theoretical equivalence showing that each NBS under specific bargaining powers is equivalent to an alternating-offer bargaining outcome for specific discount factors. This result highlights a critical limitation in the existing empirical literature: whenever estimated discount factors and bargaining powers violate this equivalence relationship, the empirical application of NBS lacks structural microfoundations.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE AND MENTORSHIP

Independent Course Instruction

Semester	Course	Format
Fall 2025	Economic Statistics	In-Person
Summer 2025	Economic Statistics	Online

Teaching Assistantships

Semester	Course	Format	Professor
Fall 2026	Microeconomics (Master's level)	In-Person	Gerald Oettinger
Spring 2026	Business Strategy	In-Person	David Sibley
Fall 2024	Empirical Public Economics	In-Person	David Sibley
Summer 2024	Macroeconomic Theory	Online	Trenton Herriford
Spring 2024	Microeconomics II (Ph.D. level)	In-Person	Svetlana Boyarchenko
Spring 2024	Introductory Game Theory	In-Person	V. Bhaskar
Fall 2023	Microeconomic Theory	In-Person	Gerald Oettinger
Summer 2023	Real Analysis (Master's level)	In-Person	Kirk Blazek
Spring 2023	Microeconomics II (Ph.D. level)	In-Person	Svetlana Boyarchenko
Fall 2022	Introductory Game Theory	In-Person	V. Bhaskar
Spring 2022	Introduction to Microeconomics	In-Person	G. Dirk Mateer
Fall 2021	Intro to Microeconomics	Online	Charity-Joy Acchiardo and G. Dirk Mateer
Fall 2020	Competitive Strategy and Industrial Organization	Online	Huseyin Yildirim (at Duke University)

Peer Educator Supervision and Mentorship

Spring 2025 Supplemental Instruction Supervisor for the Economics cohort at Sanger Learning Center, The University of Texas at Austin

- Supervised a team of peer educators running weekly sessions for core economics courses by leading workshops on active learning and inclusive pedagogy, reviewing session plans, observing live sessions to provide targeted feedback in one-on-one debriefs, and ensuring timely completion of administrative tasks.

SKILLS

Software and Tools	MATLAB, Stata, Microsoft Office, LaTeX
Languages	Mandarin (Native), English (Fluent)